SalamaLine: A Confidential Line for Girls' Safety and Wellbeing

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1. Summary

SalamaLine is a free, confidential, Swahili-first service that girls and young people can reach from any phone, including basic feature phones with no internet. Through USSD, SMS and WhatsApp it gives accurate information, points to nearby verified services, and connects a girl to a trained person when she needs help.

Its heart is **preventing child marriage and protecting girls' wellbeing**. It also addresses female genital mutilation (FGM), gender-based violence and online abuse, because these harms are connected and often reach the same girl.

Two rules shape everything. A trained human is always behind every request for help: the system never handles a crisis alone. And SalamaLine never writes its own medical or legal advice: it only shares content that professionals have approved.

2. The problem

Young people make up over 60% of Africa's population, yet adolescent girls and young women face deep inequalities. The figures below come from UNFPA's SafeTech Africa Hacklab '26 call for applications:

- 1 in 3 girls is married before the age of 18.
- The adolescent birth rate is 93 per 1,000.
- Girls account for 6 in 7 new adolescent HIV infections.
- A 26% mobile internet gender gap leaves 230 million women offline.
- Between 16% and 64% of young women experience technology-facilitated violence.

What this means for a girl on the ground

- She has no safe, private place to ask questions about her body, her rights or what is happening to her.
- Stigma, fear of family backlash and fear of being reported keep her silent.

- She often has a basic phone, little or no data, limited literacy or a disability, so smartphone apps and websites do not reach her.
- What she does find online or from peers is often inaccurate.
- She does not know where to find a clinic, legal aid, a safe shelter or a social welfare officer.
- By the time someone hears about the danger, a marriage, a cutting or an assault may already have happened.

The cost of inaction. Every unanswered question can become a forced marriage, an early pregnancy, an infection, an injury or a girl leaving school. The cost is carried by the girl first, then by her family and community through lost health, education and income.

3. What SalamaLine is

SalamaLine is a single platform, reached by dialing a short code, sending a text or messaging on WhatsApp. It makes three promises:

1. **Private.** No names, no registration. Girls can leave quickly or delete their data at any time.
2. **Reachable.** It works on any phone, with or without internet, in simple Swahili and English, with a text-only path for every service.
3. **Answered by a person.** Every request for help reaches a trained responder, with automatic follow-up if nobody replies.

Who it serves

User	What they get
Girls and young people	Private information, nearby services, a safe way to ask for help
Parents, teachers and community members	A way to raise a concern about a girl, anonymously if they choose, and guidance on what to do
Community responders	Clear alerts, a simple way to accept and close cases, and a protocol to follow
Partner organisations	Anonymous, aggregated trends to plan and report their work

4. How SalamaLine solves the problem

Barrier	How SalamaLine responds
No private place to ask	A confidential line that stores no names or message text
No smartphone or data	USSD and SMS work on any phone, with no internet
Low literacy or disability	Plain language, one question per screen, text-only paths, voice menus planned
Wrong or harmful information	Only professionally approved content is ever shared
Not knowing where to go	Verified clinics, legal aid and social welfare offices listed by district and sent by SMS
Help arrives too late	A consent-based help request alerts a trained responder, with reminders and escalation
Fear of being identified	Anonymous reporting option, quick exit and delete-my-data commands
Communities do not know what is happening	Anonymous reports from neighbours and teachers, and risk-season notices to community Champions

5. Functionalities

5.1 Reach: channels and languages

- **USSD menus** for any phone. Simple numbered choices: 0 goes back, 00 is a quick exit, 99 deletes the user's data.
- **SMS commands** such as SALAMA (menu), KLINIKI plus district (find a clinic), MSAADA plus district (ask for help), FGM plus district (urgent request), RIPOTI plus district (anonymous concern), USTAWI (wellbeing tips) and FUTA (delete my data).
- **WhatsApp** with the same text commands, kept light and screen-reader friendly.
- **Swahili and English** from the start. Voice menus and further local languages are planned.

5.2 Safe information

Short, accurate answers on child marriage, FGM, online abuse and reproductive health. Each answer comes from an approved content bank that records its source, reviewer and review date. A short version appears on the USSD screen and the full version can be sent by SMS to keep.

5.3 Nearby services

By district, the user can find verified clinics, legal aid and social welfare offices, with contact details and opening hours, and receive them by SMS. Only services that a named partner has verified are shown in live use.

5.4 Help request with consent

When a girl asks for help, SalamaLine asks for her consent before any contact. A trained responder in her district is alerted by SMS and accepts the case with a simple reply. If nobody responds, the alert is repeated and then escalated to a district focal person. When the case is closed, the girl's contact details are wiped. The system never contacts police, family or authorities by itself.

5.5 Child marriage prevention (core focus)

- Information on the harms of child marriage, her rights and where to get help.
- A consent-based help request for a girl who fears being married.
- An anonymous concern report so a teacher, neighbour or friend can alert a trained person without giving their own details.
- Referral to legal aid, social welfare and health services.
- **Planned dedicated journey:** a forced-marriage risk path, information on staying in school and returning after pregnancy, and dialogue content for parents, elders and faith leaders, designed together with child-protection partners.

5.6 FGM module

- **I am afraid I will be cut:** an urgent request with consent.
- **I am worried about a girl:** a report with optional anonymity.
- **I was cut, I need care:** nearby health and counselling services, with no alert raised.

- **Information** with facts and myths, and **risk-season notices** that warn community Champions before higher-risk periods such as school holidays, with dates set together with local partners.

5.7 Wellbeing check-in

A gentle, non-diagnostic check-in asking how the girl has been feeling. Good answers lead to approved tips. A low answer shows the helpline first and then offers a trained counsellor, if she agrees. Nothing she answers is stored or scored: only an anonymous count is kept.

5.8 Digital safety

Guidance on image abuse, sextortion and online harassment, and how to report, with deeper support to be added as the platform grows.

5.9 Privacy controls

Quick exit at any step, delete-my-data on request, neutral message wording so a phone screen reveals nothing, and no names, message text or raw phone numbers in logs.

5.10 Accessibility and inclusion

A text-only path for every service so deaf and speech-impaired users are not excluded, screen-reader-friendly WhatsApp, plain language, consistent menus, and testing with girls with disabilities, out-of-school girls and rural youth. Free access through sponsored or zero-rated short codes is being pursued with mobile operators.

5.11 Partner dashboard

Anonymous, aggregated trends by topic, district and channel, and how quickly alerts are answered. Small counts are hidden so no individual can be identified.

5.12 Modular and open source

SalamaLine is one platform with modules (safety and protection, FGM, health, digital safety, wellbeing). A new region needs a new service directory, content pack and language pack, not new code. The code will be released as open source.

6. What using it feels like

These scenarios are illustrative.

Amina, 15, with a basic phone. She hears that her family is planning her marriage. She dials the short code, chooses the help option, picks her district and agrees to be contacted. A trained responder receives an alert, contacts her safely and helps her reach the social welfare office.

A teacher who is worried about a student. She texts RIPOTI and the district name. A responder is alerted, with no information about who sent the message. The responder verifies the concern through the community protocol before acting.

A responder in the district. She receives an alert, replies ACK with the case code to accept it, and is reminded of the protocol: confirm it is safe to talk and do not contact the family without a safety plan. She replies CLOSE when done and the girl's contact details are wiped.

7. Safety, privacy and ethics

- **Minimal data.** No names, ages, message text or raw phone numbers are stored. Phone numbers are stored only as a one-way hash, or encrypted with consent for an open help request, and wiped at closure.
- **Consent first.** A responder receives a number only when the girl agrees. Declining never blocks the helpline or services.
- **Human in the loop.** The system routes requests; it does not decide, diagnose or report on its own.
- **Approved content only.** No free-form AI answers in a sensitive domain.
- **Honest about limits.** Anonymous reports are not stored with a number, but a mobile operator may still see it. Users are told this plainly.
- **Safeguarded responders.** Responders are vetted, trained and bound by confidentiality and child-protection codes.
- **Aligned with** UNFPA's safe and ethical technology guidance, the TFGBV tech-safety checklist and the UN principles for the ethical use of AI, with independent privacy and safeguarding review before any pilot.

8. What makes SalamaLine different

- It reaches girls that smartphone apps miss, with USSD and SMS first.
- It combines information, referral and human help in one flow, instead of three separate tools.
- Everything is anonymous by design and consent-based.
- Its answers are retrieved from approved sources, never invented.
- It supports the whole community, with anonymous reporting and Champions, not only the girl.
- It is open source and built to be adapted to other regions and languages.

9. Expected results

Success will be measured with anonymous, aggregated indicators, with targets agreed with partners:

- Girls and young people reached, by channel and district.
- Information requests answered and full texts sent.
- Referrals requested and completed, confirmed by partners.
- Help requests received and how quickly a responder replies.
- Share of users who are offline, low-literacy or living with disabilities.
- Anonymous community reports received and followed up.
- Satisfaction and trust, measured through feedback sessions with girls.

10. Implementation approach

Over 12 months, in five stages:

1. **Co-design and content (months 1-2).** Workshops with girls, girls with disabilities, out-of-school and rural youth; build the approved content bank and verified service directory; sign partner agreements.
2. **Build and review (months 3-4).** Finalise the platform, add security, test on real phones, and complete an independent safeguarding and privacy review.
3. **Pilot (months 5-7).** Launch in selected communities and schools in Mbeya Region, train responders and Champions, and run community dialogue sessions. A smaller, partner-led pilot of the FGM module runs in a higher-prevalence district chosen with a local organisation.

4. **Learn and improve (months 8-9).** Improve content and menus from feedback, add voice menus and strengthen SMS fallback.
5. **Scale and share (months 10-12).** Add a second language, publish an impact report, release the code openly and prepare expansion to other regions and countries.

11. Team and partners

SalamaLine is built by **signiAI**, the student community at Mbeya University of Science and Technology (MUST), led by Jofrey Nasson, with more than 150 members across seven technical groups spanning programming, networking, AI and signal processing. Young women will lead content, community outreach and testing.

Partners we will work with, each to be confirmed in writing before being named publicly:

- Health facilities and youth-friendly clinics
- Legal aid organisations
- District social welfare and community development offices
- Local organisations working on child protection and FGM
- Mental-health professionals and counsellors
- Schools and teachers
- Mobile operators and messaging providers

12. Current status

A working prototype exists, with USSD, SMS and WhatsApp handling, the information, referral and help-request services, the FGM and wellbeing modules, escalation, a partner dashboard, a home page with a live phone simulator, and 40 automated tests. Content, service contacts and Swahili wording are placeholders until reviewed by professionals, young people and native speakers. The next steps are content approval, partner agreements, the messaging gateway and the safeguarding review.

13. Conclusion

Girls at risk of child marriage, FGM and violence often have no safe place to ask a question or ask for help. SalamaLine puts that place in their hands: on any phone, in their language, private by design, and always backed by a real person. With the right partners it can

reduce harm early, connect girls to the services that already exist, and give communities a trusted way to protect their daughters.